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JFSLA Unveils Revamped SOVA Valley Food Pantry

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The SOVA Valley Food Pantry in Van Nuys celebrated its grand opening on Friday, Sept. 20, unveiling a modernized facility equipped with advanced technology and increased choices for groceries. The upgrades include an improved structure, enhanced electrical system, new air conditioning and heating capabilities, an expanded roof and larger refrigerator and freezer units. These changes empower clients to choose their own groceries in a more dignified setting.

Although none of the thousands of people served by this program, a branch of Jewish Family Services (JFS) of Los Angeles, had ever complained about the facility's previous condition, the organization was determined to enhance the overall experience. Many clients were simply grateful for the food they received twice a month, not expecting anything else. However, JFS aimed to provide more than just sustenance, it also offers social work support, assistance with finding employment and education on benefits individuals may not be aware of.

Thanks to a $6 million grant from California's budget allocation, this vision became a reality.

Now, when people arrive at the pantry, the experience feels almost like shopping at a Ralphs supermarket — except there are no cashier registers. The bright, spacious environment offers a variety of goods, from fresh produce to bakery and dairy products.

"SOVA is one of Jewish Family Service LA's core programs — it has always been more than a food pantry," said Eli Veitzer, president and CEO of Jewish Family Service LA. "Our goal is to increase access to services and reduce barriers for individuals and families in need."

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As food prices and the cost of living have surged in recent years, the demand for SOVA's services has grown as well. The ribbon-cutting ceremony was attended by notable public officials, including Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino), former State Senator Bob Hertzberg (D) and former Assemblymember Adrin Nazarian (D).

"The grand reopening of the SOVA Valley Food Pantry is a major milestone worth celebrating," said Gabriel, who also serves as the Chair of the California Legislative Jewish Caucus. "This new facility will benefit thousands of families from across the San Fernando Valley, regardless of faith or background. I am deeply grateful to the amazing team at JFSLA for their commitment to serving our most vulnerable and to former Senator Hertzberg and former Assemblymember Nazarian for leading the effort to secure the state funding that made today possible."

Nazarian, a candidate for Los Angeles City Council who served in the state Assembly until 2022, understands well what it means to have financial struggles. He and his mother fled Iran in 1981, following the revolution, when his older brother reached a drafting age. His mother did everything in her power to protect the family.

"It took us three months to flee the country and reach the U.S.," Nazarian told The Journal following the ceremony. "I was 8 years old — you don't forget something like that."

Years later, his father and brother were able to join them in the U.S. and the family was reunited. This experience as a child immigrant gives Nazarian a deep understanding of the struggles faced by many of the people supported by SOVA today.

"Thank you for transforming this small location into a welcoming center that meets each need with dignity,"

Nazarian told the attendees. "As someone who fled my home country with my family, I know the importance of having a place like this when you're just trying to survive. The work being done here ensures that all of our neighbors, no matter their background, are supported."

Every year, JFSLA's SOVA Community Food and Resource Program distributes millions of food items to tens of thousands of people. Last year alone, SOVA provided 3 million pounds of groceries to 25,000 people, with the SOVA Valley Pantry serving up to 350 people daily.

"I want to thank the California taxpayers," said former State Senator Bob Hertzberg. "It's their money and I'd argue that, dollar for dollar, given the contributions of so many volunteers, taxpayers are getting one heck of a deal. As politicians, we're just stewards of the people's money and this project demonstrates the value of government and community working together."

"Part of the reason the state invested $6 million in SOVA is because the program does thoughtful, impactful work to help a tremendous number of people," Gabriel said. "They uplift their dignity, strengthen their community and provide essential support."

"What really speaks to me is that this is such a beautiful expression of our Jewish values," Gabriel added. "People walk in here and see 'Jewish Family Services,' but those who come through the doors are from every race, ethnicity, religion, and immigration status. They come in and see that the Jewish community is here to help and serve them."

Gabriel said he was preparing his youngest child, Noah, for preschool at Valley Beth Shalom. "We gave him a dollar for tzedakah and three boxes of macaroni and cheese for SOVA and VBS. We had a conversation about why we give tzedakah every Friday and why we donate food. For me, it's a beautiful expression of Tikkun Olam. It's the essence of it."

In addition to the revitalized Van Nuys location, JFSLA's SOVA Community Food and Resource Program operates another pantry in Pico-Robertson and provides extensive outreach across Los Angeles. Through partnerships with organizations like New Economics for Women and Watts Labor Community Action Committee, SOVA runs Pop-Up Pantries at multiple sites, including a senior house site in West Hollywood and in Plummer Park to feed the homeless. JFSLA also provides food for two student-run pantries at California State University, Northridge (CSUN).

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